

Firefox vs. IE8 vs. Opera vs. Chrome

THE WAR OF THE BROWSERS

Part II

Madhusudan Mukerjee

First there was the war of the browsers in the nineties, when Netscape and Internet Explorer battled it out for space in the virtual world. But if you thought that we'd seen the end of it, here's food for thought: this monsoon it's been raining browsers. Microsoft released its Beta 2 version of Internet Explorer 8 on August 27, the Mozilla foundation brought out its 3.1 Alpha 2 update on September 5 and Opera came out with its 9.5 Beta on September 10. The most exciting thing to come out of this downpour has been, of course, Google Chrome — the much awaited browser from the guys at Mountain View — released on September 2, leaving most of us pretty impressed.

Typically, every time a new browser enters the webwork, there's a frenzy of downloads (in just two days, Chrome was downloaded enough to become one of the top 5 browsers to be used in the world), a web full of superlative adjectives ('awesome' being the most common one) and instant comparisons with older ones. So, in all that thicket of opinion, we at *Digit* decided that it's about time someone gave you the facts. We zoomed in on the top four browsers (IE8, Firefox, Opera and Chrome) and found out the truth. If you want to find out too, don't stop reading.

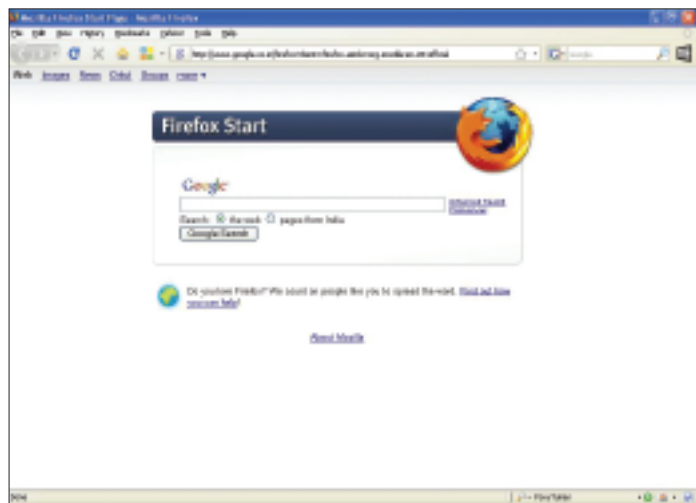
Before we make our comparative analysis, allow us to take you through some of the key features of the four most popular browsers on the Web.

Firefox 3.0.1



The second most popular browser in the world and loved by open source fans, Mozilla's Firefox 3.0.3 is lightweight (7.8 MB), safe, rich in add-ons (5,000 and counting), full of active

Internet Explorer, Firefox, Opera — and now Chrome. We compare the top internet browsers



security features (anti-phishing, pop-up blocker, password manager, parental controls) and the industry's fastest response times. Both the browser and add-ons are completely free. Until now, Google has been ardently supporting Mozilla and helping to pit Firefox against the hegemony of Internet Explorer, but with the coming of Chrome, things may change. The features that can be rated as "awesome" are plenty, but to list a few...

What's Awesome

Tabbed browsing: You don't need to open a dozen new windows to surf or search different sites simultaneously. Every new link you click on opens in a 'tab' in the same window. In fact, although Mozilla didn't start tabbed browsing, they did make it popular by incorporating it into Firefox in 2003, making it a must-have in every new browser that has come up since.

Auto Restore: If your computer crashes or hangs midway through a session, Firefox restores the